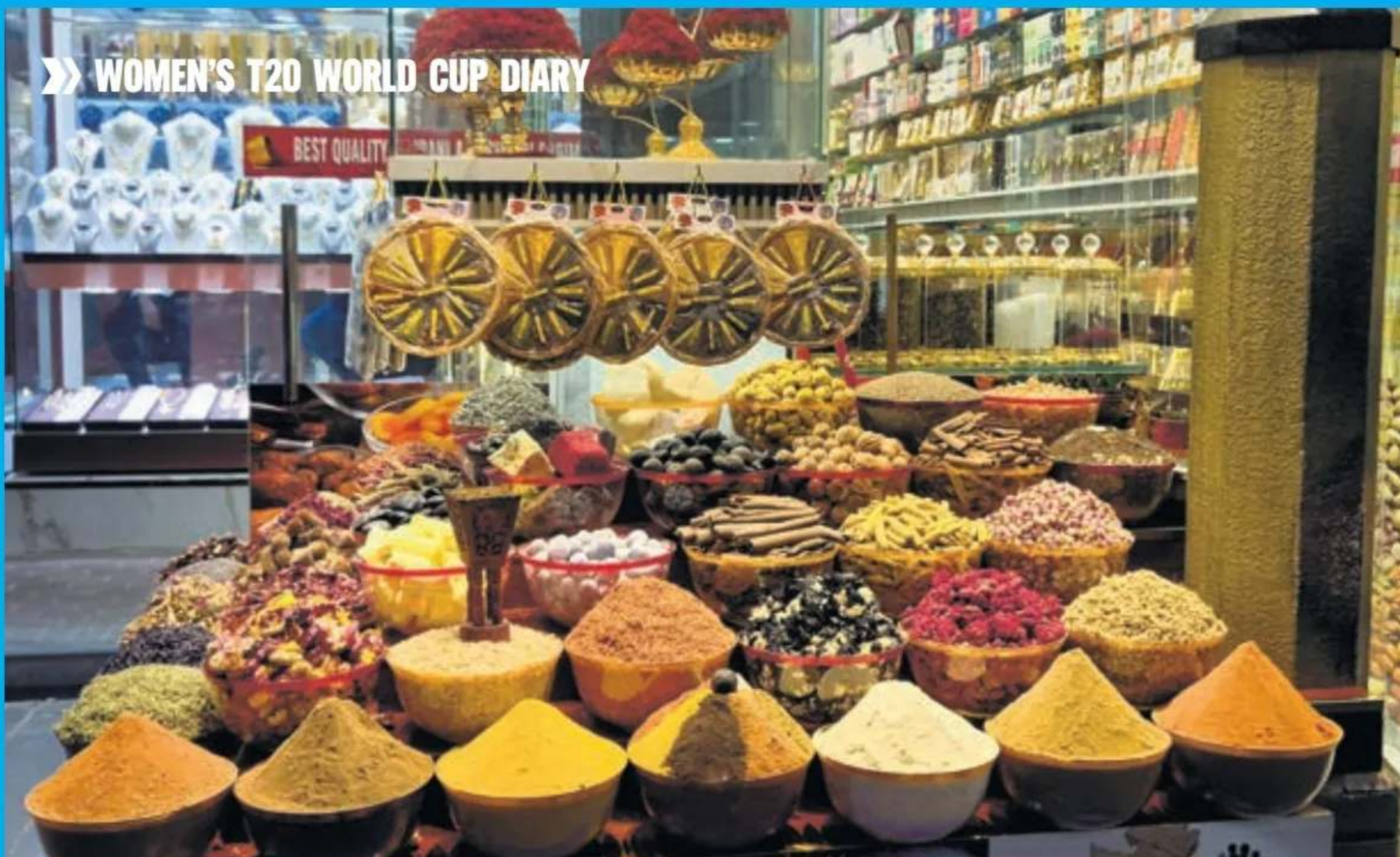




Sensory feast: Scarlet Iranian saffron and the aromas of the choicest spices enveloped the bustling souks.

LAVANYA LAKSHMI NARAYANAN

Of saffron, souks and the sun — a UAE sojourn

Dubai is the land of potentially the smoothest roads the Diary has ever travelled on, where a **warm sun** hugs your face and never lets you go.

Lavanya Lakshmi Narayanan
lavanya.ln@thehindu.co.in

Preparations for a three-week assignment in the United Arab Emirates often come with numerous warnings about the heat and humidity. As someone born and raised in Chennai — very familiar with the unforgiving sun and stickiness of the coastal city — the Diary was quite amused by these warnings, confident it would feel much like home.

And for the first week, that confidence held. The Diary was better

off than the poor folks from cooler regions, particularly the Europeans in the press box and on the field. However, nothing could prepare one for the microwave-like heat that wafted through the windows of the Emirates aircraft on landing in Dubai.

Dubai is the land of potentially the smoothest roads the Diary has ever travelled on, where a warm sun hugs your face and never lets you go, and luxury cars zoom around for hire. The Diary's driver to the Airbnb was a middle-aged gentleman originally from Balochistan, Pakistan. "Madam, aap koi match dekhne aaye ho? Kaun khel raha hai yahan ab? (Madam, are

you here to watch a game? Who's playing?)," he asked when the Diary mentioned travelling for sport. There were no banners or promotional paraphernalia in sight. You couldn't tell that the city was hosting 10 of the world's best teams.

"Women's World Cup? Pakistan bhi hai usmein? (Pakistan is playing too?)" came his next question. A cricket romantic who stopped watching after mercurial Pakistan all-rounder Shahid Afridi retired, he perked up upon hearing that a player from his province — Diana Baig — was in Dubai. When he learnt ticket prices started as low as AED 5, he